Executive Summary

This report outlines the costs associated with establishing a State Park on the Black River in Bladen, Pender, and Sampson counties. The background information, timeline, cost, and recommendation are provided in this report.

Background Information

HB353, passed by the North Carolina General Assembly (NCGA) in 2017, directed the Division of Parks and Recreation to study the feasibility and desirability of acquiring land and establishing a State Park on the Black River. The authors of this feasibility study found that the Black River is a natural area of statewide significance, sufficient size, without incompatible features, and with adequate opportunities to provide safe public access. By meeting these four essential criteria, the Black River represents a suitable location for the establishment of a state park.

Timeline and Cost

This report provides a detailed Five-Year Fiscal Impact table outlining the estimated cost of establishing, staffing, and operating the proposed state park. Capital costs associated with purchase of land and development will be incurred during the first year of the park's development at an estimated cost of ~$6.3 million. Estimated operating costs vary from year to year, averaging ~$0.54 million over the first two years and ~$0.81 million over the next three years once the park has been fully opened. These operating costs include salary and benefits for the park's employees.

Recommendation

Based on the estimated cost, it is the recommendation of the authors of this report that the State of North Carolina move forward with the establishment of a State Park on the Black River. The total cost of establishing this park is well within the budget granted by the NCGA. The capital expenditures ($6.3 million) are covered by the $28 million appropriated to the Parks and Recreation Trust Fund (PARTF), while the operating costs (< $1 million per year) are within the $75.2 million budgeted for State Parks operations.